Your first five minutes with your data

Smart Logistics (EDSLOG.24) · one page · lesson 3, with the datasets

You do not need a BI tool, statistics or programming for this course. You need four moves in Excel — **open · filter · group · join** — and one habit: **check**. Your lecturer does this once in front of the class. This page is so you can do it again on your own data.

The example uses `stores.csv` and `sites.csv` from the **public** data folder, so every department has them. 120 rows, small enough to see what you are doing. Your own files are larger; the moves are identical.

0 · Open it so the numbers are numbers

Do not double-click a `.csv`. In Excel: **Data → From Text/CSV**, delimiter **comma**, file origin **65001 UTF-8**, and — the one that goes wrong on a Dutch laptop — decimal separator a **full stop**, not a comma. Then **Load**.

You know it went wrong if a column of numbers is left-aligned, or if `52.1918` became 521918. Undo and import again; never repair it by hand.

Then: **Ctrl+End** (how many rows and columns?), **View → Freeze Top Row**, and open the `data_dictionary.csv` that sits next to every dataset. Two minutes here saves an hour later.

1 · Filter — make the file smaller before you calculate

Select the header row → **Data → Filter**. On `ze_zone`, tick only `TRUE`. The status bar bottom left now reads **22 of 120 records found**. That is the point: you are looking at 22 stores in a zero-emission zone, and you can see that you are.

2 · Group — a PivotTable answers "how much per ..."

Click in the table → **Insert → PivotTable → New sheet**. **Rows:** `assigned_dc_fresh`. **Values:** `store_id` set to **Count**, and `sales_area_m2` set to **Sum**.

Result: RDC-ZWO 60 stores, 85,180 m² · RDC-NIJ 60 stores, 82,820 m².

The setting that catches everybody: Excel guesses Count or Sum. Click the field → *Value Field Settings* and say which you want. Counting sales area, or summing store numbers, gives a confident and meaningless number.

3 · Join — pull a column out of another file

Your pivot says `RDC-ZWO`; the readable name is in `sites.csv`. Import that as a second sheet, then next to the pivot:

```
=XLOOKUP(A4, sites!A:A, sites!B:B, "not found")
```

Find the value of A4 in the first column of `sites`, give me what stands beside it in the second, and say so if there is no match. Older Excel: `=VLOOKUP(A4, sites!A:B, 2, FALSE)`. **Always give that fourth argument.** A join that silently drops rows is the most common way to be wrong here with a number that looks fine.

4 · Check — three checks, every time

1. **Does the total still add up?** 60 + 60 = 120 rows; 85,180 + 82,820 = 168,000 m² = the sum of the whole column.
2. **Did rows disappear in the join?** Count before and after. If the number changed, find out *which* rows before you go on.
3. **Is the answer a plausible size?** An average store of 1,400 m² is a supermarket; 14 m² is a mistake somewhere.

Then write it down in one sentence **with the filter you used**. A number without its filter is not a finding.

When it goes wrong

What you see	What it usually is
Numbers left-aligned, or sums that stay 0	imported as text — re-import with the right decimal separator
`#N/A` in a lookup column	no match: a typo, a space, or a value that genuinely is not there
Row count changed after a join	the join dropped non-matching rows. Information, not a bug — go and see which
A count where you wanted a sum	*Value Field Settings*
A total that is far too small	you are on a **sample** file: find `sample_fraction` and divide by it

Two last things. Read the *Dataset guide* before you conclude anything: it lists the traps in these files, and they are deliberate. And in a real data project, preparing the data is normally the most expensive step of all — here we did it for you.

> **GenAI transparency.** Written with Claude (Anthropic) as part of the FreshWay case design; every figure recomputed from `stores.csv` and `sites.csv`. Human-AI Agency Label: **Co-Creator**. Label source: Boetje, J., & Baake, G. (2026). *Nine prototypical human-AI agency patterns* [Figure]. figshare. https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.31706884 (CC BY 4.0).